

Co-creating Organic Learning for Methodology through “Methodology Mall”

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Abstract

The Methodology Mall, introduced by EvalYouth Asia in December 2024, is an innovative learner-centred facilitation method that redefines traditional capacity-building approaches in evaluation methods. By positioning participants as primary knowledge contributors, the method fostered a collaborative and dynamic learning environment where teams explored six evaluation methodologies through interactive peer engagement and expert inputs. The learners had to proactively search for new knowledge, share insights, and refine their understanding through a gamified process. The initiative highlights the potential of participant-led learning to enhance comprehension and practical application, offering a replicable method for engaging, experiential learning in diverse professional settings.

Keywords: *evaluation capacity building, methodology, learner-centred*

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I. Context

In December 2024, during the 5th Asia Pacific Winter School for Young Emerging Evaluators in Colombo, the event organising team, composed of young evaluation professionals from EvalYouth Asia, introduced an innovative learner-centred session named the Methodology Mall. This session challenged conventional pedagogical paradigms. By inverting the conventional expert-led approach, the session positioned participants as primary sources of knowledge, fostering an organic and participatory learning environment. The core innovation lay in developing a self-organised learning space where participants could actively share, test, and refine their understanding, with evaluation experts providing nuanced support. This approach underscores the potential of collaborative, participant-driven learning experiences. The present article aims to document this learner-centred pedagogy, offering insights for replicating an engaging and interactive learning method.

The authors' journey to become evaluation professionals reflects the Roman philosopher Seneca's words, "When we teach, we learn" (Seneca, c. 65 AD). Empirical research shows that when students teach a topic to someone else, they exert a greater cognitive effort to learn the topic compared to students learning for themselves (Duran, 2016; Granger, 2017). Based on this principle,

the format of the active learning session was conceptualised using the marketplace format in Robert Chambers' Participatory Workshops (Chambers, 2002) and the Innovation Bazaar hosted at every EvalFest (2018, 2020, 2022, and 2024)⁶, which provided a dynamic platform for showcasing creative evaluation methodologies. In this session, the presenters were participating YEEs from diverse organisations sharing innovative approaches, such as participatory sensemaking with visual maps and youth-led research methodologies, fostering collaborative feedback and learning. This interactive exchange enabled participants to explore evaluation methods, contributing to the broader understanding of their applicability in real-world contexts.

II. What is the Methodology Mall?

A participant described the "Methodology Mall" session as "a dynamic and innovative approach to exploring various evaluation methodologies", expressing delight in "the hands-on, interactive nature of the session, which allowed participants to 'shop' for methodologies tailored to their contexts."

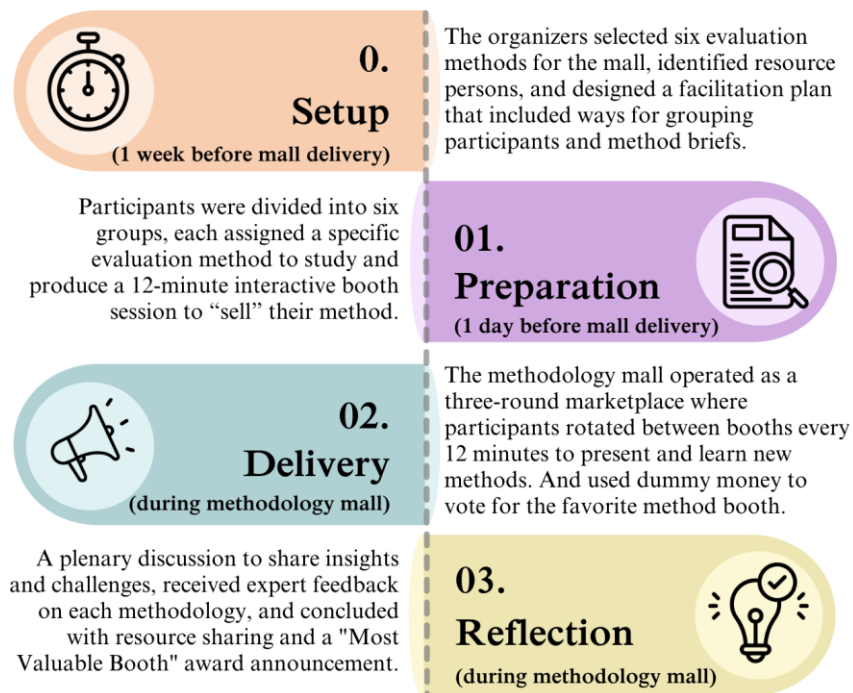
The Methodology Mall was designed in four stages: setup, preparation, delivery, and reflection (see Figure 1). A total of 32 young emerging evaluators (aged between 19 and 38, including 17 females) from 12 countries participated in the session. The organising team, who are also young emerging evaluators, led the

⁶ EvalFest is a biennial, international conference organised by the Evaluation Community of India and EvalYouth India. Ms Rituu B. Nanda leads the Innovation Bazaar event in every EvalFest and it curates multiple new ideas which participants engage with in a structured fashion.

facilitation of the session. The session aimed to build the participants'

understanding of key evaluation methods through an active learning approach.

Figure 1. Process of Methodology Mall



Setup stage:

A diverse set of evaluation methods was selected by the organising team based on their collective knowledge, interests, and relevance to the current evaluation landscape. These included outcome harvesting, desktop review, most significant change, contribution analysis, randomised control trials, and success case methods. The participants were divided into six groups, and one method was assigned to each group. The participants were provided a brief with a basic introduction of the methods at the start of the session. Two resource persons who are well-versed in various methods were also identified to support onsite during the session. The flow, format, and session logistics were also prepared at this stage.

Preparation stage:

The Methodology Mall was announced to the participants on the first day of the winter school, a day before it happened. Participants met their randomly assigned groupmates and discussed the method they were going to "sell", which was given to each group with a set of questions to guide self-learning and preparation. Each group was required to develop a 12-minute interactive session introducing their assigned method and create a method poster using flip chart papers, sticky notes, and markers. Also, each group had to ensure that every group member could present the method confidently.

In the poster, they were required to articulate the assigned method's definition, explain its practical implementation process, and explore

both appropriate and inappropriate usage contexts. They were also asked to identify complementary methods and potential strategic combinations, share practical lessons learned from previous experiences (if they have employed the method in their work), and highlight unresolved questions or challenges. They had to present this work at their stall in the mall to everyone present, including participants from other groups, facilitators, organising team members, and other evaluators who walked in during the session.

The suggested session format was a seven-minute presentation, followed by four to five minutes of questions and answers. Several rounds of 12-minute sessions. After each round, the audience of each group's stall was requested to move to the next group. Groups were also encouraged to change the presenters, so everyone could visit every stall in the mall.

The groups were given time to prepare after day 1 of winter school. They dedicated one to three hours to studying the methods, creating posters, and preparing for the presentation. During the

preparation, participants were actively facilitating themselves in studying the methods, synthesising their knowledge on the poster, and identifying areas requiring expert input. This process significantly enhanced their engagement in the workshop and ensured a participant-led session.

"I had an amazing experience at the "Methodology Mall" session. Being new to the field of Monitoring and Evaluation, I was fortunate to be surrounded by participants who encouraged me and explained everything thoroughly. This support helped me to further research the methods we were showcasing in the Methodology Mall." – Participant

Delivery stage:

The Methodology Mall was set up like a real marketplace. The session had three rounds, 12 minutes each. Every participant hosted their own booth at one assigned corner in the room and could visit two other booths during the other rounds. To make it more engaging, everyone received dummy money to "pay" for the presentations they found most valuable.



Photo 1. Booth hosts "selling" the method to the "customers"

The process worked as follows: Each person received five units of dummy money at the start. After participants visited all booths they wanted, they could put the money in that booth's collection bowl if they found the sharing valuable. A facilitator kept track of time and directed everyone when to move to the next booth. All participants had to move at the same time, including those running the booths.

The dummy money created an engaging dynamic. Participants paid close attention to each presentation because they needed to decide where to "invest" their money. They asked thoughtful questions and became actively involved in discussions. This turned into a friendly competition to see which methods would receive the most money. The only rule

was that participants could not put money in their own booth's bowl.

The resource persons' engagement was a critical component of the session. All teachers of the winter school were invited to participate, with three subject matter experts (two methods for each) strategically engaged to provide in-depth interactions. These experts actively challenged booth hosts with probing questions, transforming the session into a vibrant, knowledge-exchange environment.

"It (the session) offered a platform to learn and gain a deeper understanding of these methodologies in an efficient and interactive manner. The session's format, allowing participants to move between booths and engage directly with presenters, made it highly engaging and dynamic." – Participant



Photo 2. "Customers", including both resource persons and YEEs, vote for their favourite booth with "money"

Reflection stage:

After the marketplace, the final part allowed participants to reflect on the methodologies explored and synthesise their key takeaways with the resource persons' support. In this plenary discussion, each group shared insights, challenges, and questions raised during the presentation and interactions. This collaborative space encouraged participants to build upon each other's ideas, offering diverse perspectives on the methodologies and their applications.

To deepen the learning, experts' feedback was integrated into the reflections. Resource persons offered

constructive reflections, highlighting the strengths of each methodology and identifying areas for further exploration. This session helped to solidify understanding and address any unresolved questions from the earlier rounds.

Method resource experts provided final comments and key insights, synthesising the learning from each booth. The session concluded with additional resource sharing and the announcement of a "Most Valuable Booth" award, which added a competitive element to the learning experience.



Photo 3. Announcing the results of the most valuable booth

The overall session was conducted in 90 minutes. The session flow is presented below.

Table 1. Session time allocation

Items	Time (mins)
Session brief	7
Marketplace	12 x 3 rounds
Plenary Q&A	48
Announcing the result of most valuable booth	5

III. What is new?

Traditional training typically relies on instructors predominantly transmitting knowledge to passive recipients. In contrast, the active learning format, like “marketplace” by Chambers (2002),

reimagines the learning process by placing the learner at the centre of knowledge creation. The Methodology Mall advanced that concept by adding a preparation stage to help participants to become a method trainer first, to

strengthen that learning process. Also, by adding the “money” element to gamify the process, a friendly competition is created. The marketplace on site was very lively with yelling, laughter, and sizzling discussions.

The Methodology Mall empowers learners to actively study, think critically, and collaboratively share insights. The iterative learning cycle is enriched through multidirectional feedback mechanisms, including self-reflection, peer interaction, and expert guidance, thereby deepening and strengthening the learning experience. In addition, the process also adds a bond between the teammates. All participants took photos with the poster they co-produced to showcase their learning results.

“This (the Methodology Mall) was the most exciting part of the winter school... It really allowed us to brainstorm together, become better friends, and understand the ins and outs of methodology.” – Participant

The Methodology Mall method demonstrates the potential for innovative, learner-centred learning models that challenge conventional learning formats. By prioritising active participation, collaborative knowledge construction, and dynamic interaction, such approaches offer promising alternatives to traditional learning methodologies.



Photo 4. Participants are proud of what they produced

IV. What are the learnings?

While participants and resource persons praised the approach as engaging and innovative, they also offered constructive suggestions for future improvement.

Enhance methodological guidance and structured support: The session was very dynamic, but sometimes participants felt lost during the process. They only focused on one method most of the time, and moved around in the method mall when they might not know much about what to expect. To improve it, making a brief overview of all methods in the mall as required pre-reading for everyone, would help participants anticipate what to expect. Additionally, the plenary session could benefit from a concise introductory overview of each method, particularly useful for participants who may not have visited some booths. To make the information even more grounded, if time permits, the session can also incorporate scenario-based learning where participants can think about how the method can be used in real contexts.

Extend session duration:

"The time allocated for this activity felt too short, limiting our ability to explain our methods in detail to visitors and to explore other stalls in-depth. Extending the duration of this activity would enhance the learning experience for everyone involved." – Participant

The session was 90 minutes, including the delivery and reflection stage, which was barely enough for meaningful interaction

and discussion. It can be increased by 30-60 minutes to ensure more in-depth discussion. Depending on the availability of time, more stages can be innovated for the session, such as a debriefing discussion or a practical problem-solving assignment.

Methodology Mall turned passive learning into an active learner-centred experience, guided by questions and experience exchange. By positioning participants as primary knowledge contributors, the method fostered a collaborative and dynamic learning environment where teams explored six evaluation methodologies through interactive self-learning, peer engagement, and expert inputs. The initiative highlights the potential of participant-led learning to enhance comprehension and practical application, offering a replicable facilitation method for engaging, experiential learning in diverse professional settings.

V. Declaration of Conflicting Interest Statement

The Author(s) declare(s) that there is no conflict of interest.

VI. Acknowledgement

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